is a closed environment and the resident is elderly or bed-bound. However, if there are open windows/ doors, their effect is negated," cautions Dr Puneet Khanna, head of the department and consultant, pulmonology, Manipal Hospital, Dwarka, Delhi.

Doctors say the only purifier to trust is one with a high-efficiency particulate air (HEPA) filter, which efficiently removes pollutants. High-end establishments, too, have capitalised on clean air, turning it into a luxury amenity. The Taj Palace Hotel in New Delhi, for example, offers guests air quality index (AQI) levels below 50 while the city's AQI outside often soars past 400 in winter. Shopping malls and even restaurants have begun installing sophisticated air purification systems with HEPA filters and ionisers as part of their branding. But doctors are not entirely convinced by this trend. "Although air purifiers may enhance indoor air quality, their value in areas with high pollution levels is questionable," says Dr Dosi. "The air outside remains toxic, and individuals are still exposed to dangerous pollutants upon leaving these establishments."

Beyond air purifiers, people have turned to products marketed as air-purifying paints and even plants to keep their homes pollution-free. One of the most persistent indoor pollutants is formaldehyde—a volatile organic compound (VOC), that is, carbon-based chemicals emitted as gases from certain solids or liquids—found in wood furniture, disinfectants, glue and insulation materials. These products continuously release formaldehyde as a colourless gas, contaminating indoor air for years. To counter this, homeowners are increasingly turning to low-VOC paints, air-purifying paints, anti-formaldehyde coatings, anti-bacterial finishes and photocatalytic paints that use sunlight and organic compounds to break down pollutants. "Anti-pollution paint is a new technology. It contains titanium dioxide, which breaks down pollutants like nitrogen oxides into less harmful compounds when exposed to sunlight.... Indoors, it works best where light exposure is higher," explains Dr Dosi. Though the technology has potential, he adds, its cumulative effect is under research.

Homeowners are also investing in air-purifying plants, which are believed to absorb toxins and improve indoor air quality. Varieties like areca palm, spider plant, peace lily and aloe vera are particularly popular for their reported ability to filter formaldehyde and carbon monoxide. Though doctors say these plants have a negligible impact, they do serve as a natural and aesthetically pleasing addition to pollution-control efforts.

Then there are those who have taken their commitment to cleaner air even further by adopting smog-harvesting devices that capture airborne pollutants and convert them into ink. "I read about large-scale industrial devices being used to turn air carbon into ink and decided to purchase a smaller version for my home from the US. I've placed it near our generator to absorb emissions—now we can run it guilt-free during the summer months," says Manik Sharma, a 48-year-old financial consultant from Delhi.

By far, the most widely known anti-pollution trend remains oxygen bars, like the one Mitali visits every week. Each session costs about Rs 1,000-2,000. Some establishments, like Mumbai's Oxybank, even provide flavoured oxygen: lavender, orange, cinnamon, peppermint and so on. They work on a simple principle: 'breathe in pure oxygen to remain healthy'. That's also the principle behind hyperbaric oxygen therapy (HBOT), a medical treatment that involves breathing 100 per cent oxygen in a pressurised chamber. When pure oxygen is administered at high pressures, it dissolves in the plasma, and not the haemoglobin, thus boosting oxygen levels in the blood. This aids healing and reduces side effects of chemotherapy, radiation and other medical conditions for which it is approved. Now, various spas and non-medically certified centres have also started offering recreational HBOT,



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